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EDITORIAL

Meaning as a Subject of Scientific Psychology

On the Launch of the Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology

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ABSTRACT

This issue marks the launch of the Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology. The editorial outlines the journal's aims as a scholarly forum for the study of meaning in life, values, and existential concerns in psychology and psychotherapy. It starts from the observation that logotherapy, founded by Viktor E. Frankl, and contemporary empirical research on meaning have often developed in parallel rather than in dialogue. The journal seeks to bring these traditions into critical conversation without committing itself to any single therapeutic school. The editorial introduces the thematic focus of the first issue, which situates logotherapy within psychotherapy research: a review on the question of evidence, a theoretical paper on meaning in life as a transdiagnostic factor, a comparison of paradoxical intention with contemporary exposure-based treatments, and a methodological paper on the assessment of meaning in life. Finally, it sets out the journal's editorial principles, including a cautious and source-faithful reporting of empirical findings, a clear distinction between anthropological assumptions and empirically testable claims, and adherence to the citation guidelines of the American Psychological Association.

Keywords: meaning in life · logotherapy · psychotherapy research · editorial · philosophy of science

Aims of the Journal

The question of the meaning of one's own life is among the oldest themes of human self-reflection. As a subject of scientific psychology, however, it long played a marginal role. As early as the middle of the 20th century, Viktor E. Frankl put forward, with logotherapy, a psychotherapeutic approach that conceives of the striving for meaning as a fundamental human motivation (Frankl, 1946). Over the past two decades, empirical research on meaning has developed into an independent field of research that encompasses conceptual differentiations – for instance between coherence, purpose, and significance (Martela & Steger, 2016) – as well as the question of how prevalent the experience of meaning actually is in everyday life (Heintzelman & King, 2014).

The Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology (Zeitschrift für Sinnzentrierte Psychologie, ZSP) seeks to take up these developments and to offer a forum for scientifically rigorous discussion. It regards itself neither as the organ of a single school nor as a place for the uncritical cultivation of tradition. Rather, its aim is to bring the anthropological and clinical insights of logotherapy and existential analysis into dialogue with the methodological awareness and the findings of contemporary psychotherapy research. This includes a willingness to examine cherished assumptions of one's own tradition just as critically as reductive operationalizations of a complex phenomenon.

That meaning can be a legitimate subject of empirical research was by no means always self-evident. For a long time, the question of meaning was considered too vague, too ideologically charged, or too much a matter for philosophy to be investigated psychologically. The development of reliable measurement instruments and differentiated theoretical models has changed this assessment. At the same time, there is a risk of reducing the phenomenon to what can easily be measured. A journal devoted to meaning must therefore accomplish both: methodological rigor and openness to the phenomenological complexity of its subject.

On the Focus of This Issue

The first issue is devoted to the focus "Logotherapy in the Context of Psychotherapy Research." The review by the Psychotherapy Research unit asks about the state of the evidence for logotherapeutic and meaning-centered interventions and shows that the answer depends substantially on which understanding of evidence is taken as a basis (Vos et al., 2015; Wampold & Imel, 2015). A theoretical contribution discusses the extent to which meaning in life can be understood as a transdiagnostic factor. A further contribution compares paradoxical intention with contemporary exposure procedures and works out similarities as well as differences in the assumed mechanisms of action. The issue concludes with a methods paper on established procedures for assessing meaning in life, which comparatively presents the strengths and limitations of the available instruments.

What the contributions share is an effort toward conceptual clarity. A construct such as "meaning," which is used in different ways in everyday language, philosophy, and psychology, in particular calls for careful specification before it can be adequately measured, investigated, or addressed therapeutically.

Editorial Principles

The ZSP publishes theoretical contributions, reviews, methods papers, contributions from practice and teaching, as well as book reviews. The editors attach importance to empirical findings being reported cautiously and faithfully to their sources, to limitations of the evidence being openly acknowledged, and to anthropological premises being distinguished from empirically testable statements. Didactic case examples are explicitly identified as constructed teaching vignettes. Citations follow the guidelines of the American Psychological Association (2020).

We thank all units of the Institute that have contributed to the success of this first issue, and we warmly invite our readers to accompany the discussion critically.

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